NIGERIA · 183 CITIES · 1990 TO 2020

A centre that holds less

The share of people at the heart of Nigeria's cities, 1990 to 2020

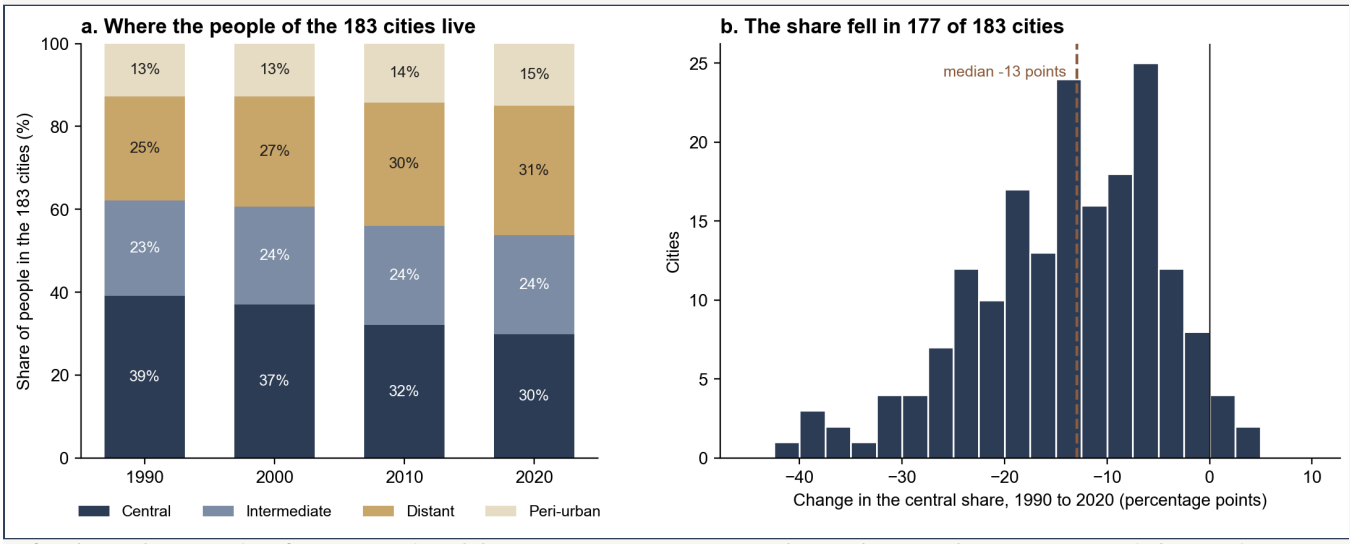
Wisdom Akpabio · October 2026

Rings and zones around each city's centre, adapted from Peraza-Mues, Resendiz, Figueroa-Soriano, Prieto-Curiel and Ponce-Lopez (2025).

Between 1990 and 2020 the centres of Mexico's cities lost 2.5 million residents while their edges filled. Did Nigeria's cities do the same? This brief follows 183 Nigerian cities that already existed in 1990. Each city gets one centre, rings 100 metres wide around it, and four zones scaled to its size: central, intermediate, distant and peri-urban. People come from GHS-POP, a satellite-based population grid at 100 metres.

The centre's share fell almost everywhere

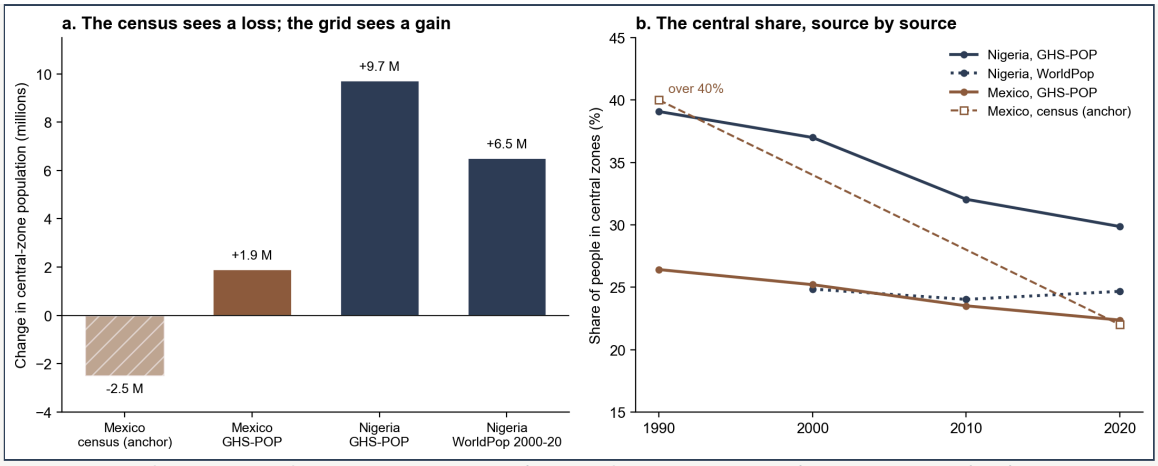
In 1990, 39.1% of the people in these cities lived in a central zone. By 2020 it was 29.9%. The share fell in 177 of the 183 cities, by a median of 13 points. Most of the 44.8 million people added went further out: 16.4 million to the distant zones, 11.0 million to the intermediate, 7.6 million to the peri-urban, and 9.7 million to the centres.



Left, where the people of 183 cities lived, by zone, 1990 to 2020. Right, each city's change in central share. Almost every bar sits below zero.

Why the counts are not trusted

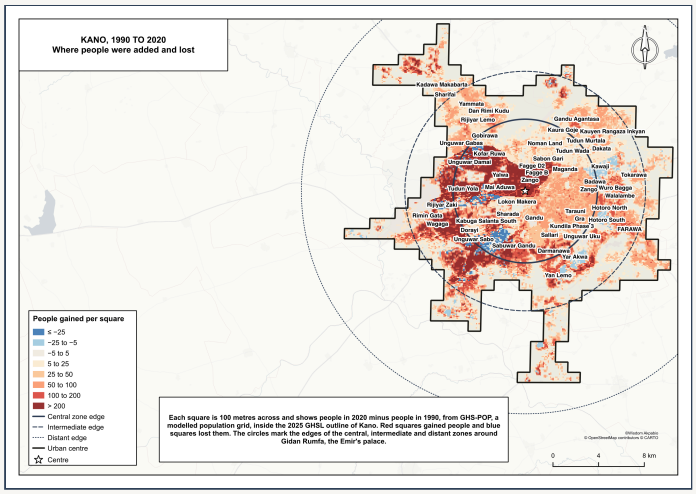
The grid says Nigeria's central zones gained 9.7 million people, which reads like the opposite of Mexico. It is not evidence of that. Run through the same steps, the same grid turns Mexico's census loss of 2.5 million into a gain of 1.9 million. It gets the direction of the share right in Mexico, falling in 88 of 92 cities, but not the count. A second grid, WorldPop, barely changes shape from year to year, so it cannot settle the question either.



Left, change in central-zone people. Mexico's census shows a loss; GHS-POP shows a gain in both countries. Right, the central share, source by source.

The biggest cities held on

Size is the exception. In cities of under a million, the central share fell by a median of 13 to 14 points. In the fourteen cities of over a million it fell by 3.7. Lagos moved by one point, Port Harcourt by two, and Kano by seven, though Kano still keeps more than half its people within 6.3 kilometres of the Emir's palace. Benin City fell by 15.



Kano, 1990 to 2020. Red squares gained people, blue squares lost them. The circles mark the central, intermediate and distant zones. On this grid the old city still gained, but see the Mexican test above.

What this means

What the satellite record can carry in Nigeria is the share: the place most new urban Nigerians settled was away from the old centre, in small and middle-sized cities most of all. Whether those centres emptied, as Mexico's did, needs a census. Nigeria's last was in 2006. A count by enumeration area in Lagos Island, Kano's walled city, Mapo Hill and the old cores of the middle-sized cities would answer it.

What this does not show

These are modelled people, spread from satellite-mapped buildings, inside city outlines held at their 2025 extent. Each city has one centre: a founding place in the four oldest, the Three Arms Zone in Abuja, the densest 1975 built-up point elsewhere. The paper's model of how cities stretch rests on the same counts, so it is not leaned on.